

Teaching Statement

Dayanara M. Díaz Vargas

Department of Economics, Northeastern University

Every student brings different strengths to a classroom. Some develop their ideas through discussion, while others benefit from working independently or asking questions. For those who are less comfortable speaking in front of their peers, participating can be challenging. My teaching responds to these differences through three priorities: offering multiple ways to participate and demonstrate understanding, connecting economic concepts to current data and research, and cultivating students' ability to work together.

I have led recitation sections of Principles of Macroeconomics in five terms since Summer 2024, supporting a 400-student lecture course. In the weekly discussion I designed, each idea reaches students more than one way, as I write the equation on the board while students look up a definition or a fact on their laptops, we match what they find to the equation, and students then work through it in randomly assigned groups of three. I don't call on students at random, because I understand some feel uncomfortable being the center of attention or speaking in front of the room. Instead, I ask open questions and wait for a volunteer. As the semester goes on and students grow familiar with me and with one another, more of them volunteer. Some of the feedback I have received from my students on what I should keep doing has been "*Providing examples*", "*definitely asking questions*", and "*Great attitude and seemed like she actually wanted to be there and help students.*"

I push students toward their highest potential as future economists by picking their interest with current statistics and research. After we build an equation, I bring up World Bank or FRED data and ask students to interpret the indicators against it. When we discussed how imports affect manufacturing jobs at home, I wrote Autor, Dorn, and Hanson's work on the China shock on the board, and students were curious enough to take a new interest in the class. Before the first exam, I built the review session from the misconceptions I see most often in homework. It puts the most weight on separating what shifts a curve from what causes a movement along it, and on converting current dollars into past dollars and back. Every wrong option of its 25 questions was a common mistake students make.

Teamwork is central to the semester-long case study project in my recitations. Working in groups of two or three, students select a country and develop five case studies examining its macroeconomic performance. I guide each group through all five studies and evaluate its presentation. Alongside their understanding of macroeconomics, the project develops their ability to collaborate, a skill that employers value when assessing new graduates.

As a teaching assistant, I have graded exams, problem sets, discussion boards, case studies, and presentations. As a faculty member, I would retain this variety, giving students multiple ways to demonstrate their understanding. My teaching interests include Principles of Macroeconomics, Principles of Microeconomics, Microeconomic Theory, Statistics, and Econometrics, as well as Health Economics and Labor Economics.